

06a Translation Preparation: Meaning-Based Translation – WT

(Slide deck; white board – 45 min.)

Intro: There are different styles of translation. In this session, we are going to talk about a style called meaning-based translation.

Explain first what we mean by a “meaning-based translation.” **Meaning-based translation** does not focus so much on individual **words** but instead on the overall **meaning** of the message.

A **literal translation** tries to restate every word of the message, one by one, as directly as possible.

Wycliffe Associates embraces the idea that **the message** of the original should be translated in a way so that its **meaning** will be most likely to be understood by the speakers of that language. **This is meaning-based translation.**

Almost all oral interpretation is expected to be meaning-based. When translating Scripture, one can become worried about every single word in case of saying something sacrilegious. However, the **meaning** and **message** of Scripture is what is sacred. The message must be recreated in heart-language words that express its meaning not only in an **accurate** way, but also in a **natural** and **clear** way. And that will often require adjustment to certain words, and even to the word order.

For example, a word-by-word direct translation of “Mucho gusto. Me llamo Juan” from Spanish to English would be “Much I like. Myself I call John.” A meaning-based translation would be “Nice to meet you. My name is John.” If you speak more than one language, when you interpret from one language to the other, you are most likely engaging in meaning-based translation.

Explain: There will be particular words that will later need some special care, for their meaning to come through most clearly in the heart language. However, these particular words will be addressed in the checking steps (last 4 steps), rather than during the initial translation (first 4 drafting steps). *(This will prepare the way for later steps, such as the DFT discussion.)*

Ask: What would their Scripture translation be like if they translated it literally?

Explain: WA developed an 8-Step process to aid translators in creating a meaning-based translation in their mother tongue. In the next two sessions, we will be speaking about these 8 steps of translation.

Confirm: Express that the 8 steps are designed to create a meaning-based translation. That means the translation will sound natural and clear in their heart language and will also have an accurate correspondence to the meaning of each passage of Scripture, when they faithfully follow the 8 steps.